THE 25-POINT

Home Electrical Safety Checklist

A walk-through every Long Island homeowner should do once a year. If you check more than 3 boxes, it's time for a professional inspection.

Why this matters

Electrical fires cause an estimated 51,000 home fires each year in the U.S. Most are preventable. This checklist takes about 20 minutes and could save your home — and your family.

How to use this checklist

Walk through your home with this PDF and a flashlight. Check off each box as you confirm it. Pay extra attention to items marked **RED FLAG** — those mean stop and call a licensed electrician.

1. Electrical Panel & Breakers

- [ ] Panel is easily accessible — no boxes, shelving, or laundry blocking it (must have 3 ft of clearance).
- [ ] Panel cover is in place, with no exposed wires or burn marks.
- [ ] Breakers are clearly labeled (kitchen, bedroom 1, garage, etc.).
- [ ] No breakers feel warm to the touch.
- [ ] No breakers trip repeatedly when you use everyday appliances.

RED FLAG: If your panel says Federal Pacific (FPE / Stab-Lok), Zinsco, or Sylvania, or if your home still has a fuse box, replace it. These are documented fire hazards.

2. Outlets & Switches

- [ ] No outlets are warm, discolored, or buzzing.
- [ ] Two-prong outlets have been replaced with grounded three-prong (or GFCI).
- [ ] Outlets within 6 ft of any sink, in bathrooms, garage, and outdoors are GFCI protected.
- [ ] All bedroom outlets are AFCI protected (required by current NEC).
- [ ] No cracked faceplates or loose outlets that wiggle when you plug something in.
- [ ] Tamper-resistant outlets installed in homes with young children.

3. Cords & Plugs

- [ ] No extension cords are being used as permanent wiring.
- [ ] No cords run under rugs, through walls, or across doorways.
- [ ] Power strips are not daisy-chained (plugged into other power strips).
- [ ] High-draw appliances (space heaters, A/C units, microwaves) are plugged directly into the wall.

4. Lighting & Fixtures

- [ ] Every bulb in every fixture is at or below the rated wattage on the socket.
- [ ] No flickering lights when other appliances turn on.
- [ ] Recessed lights have proper IC-rated cans if they touch insulation.
- [ ] Outdoor fixtures are rated for wet/damp locations.

5. Smoke & CO Detectors

- [ ] Smoke detector on every floor and inside every bedroom.
- [ ] Carbon monoxide detector within 15 ft of every sleeping area.
- [ ] All detectors tested in the last 30 days; batteries changed annually.
- [ ] Detectors are less than 10 years old (check the date on the back).

6. EV Charger / Garage

- [ ] EV charger is on a dedicated circuit (not shared with garage outlets).
- [ ] Garage outlets are GFCI protected.
- [ ] Service panel has spare capacity for future EV / heat pump / pool loads.

7. Outdoor & Service Entrance

- [ ] Service entrance cable from the pole/meter shows no fraying or exposed copper.
- [ ] Meter pan and weather head are sealed and rust-free.
- [ ] Outdoor outlets have weatherproof in-use covers.

Your score

0–2 unchecked: You're in great shape. Re-run this checklist next year.
3–6 unchecked: Schedule a free inspection — small issues become expensive ones.
7+ unchecked, or any RED FLAG: Stop. Call a licensed electrician this week.

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This checklist is provided for educational purposes. It does not replace a professional inspection by a licensed electrician. When in doubt, always call a pro.